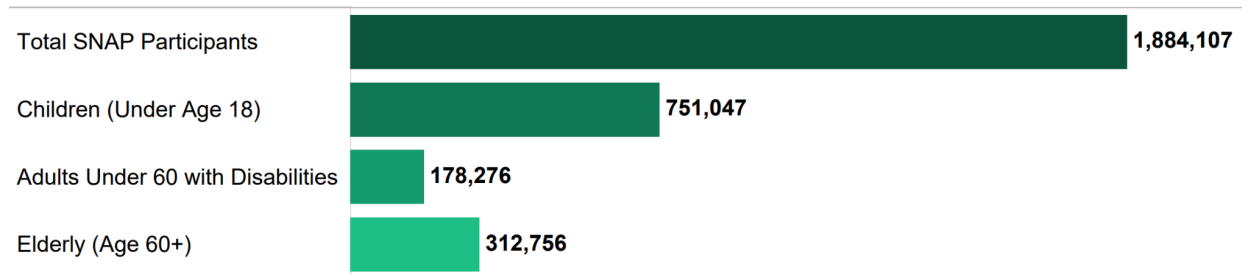


Chicago, IL - Case Study

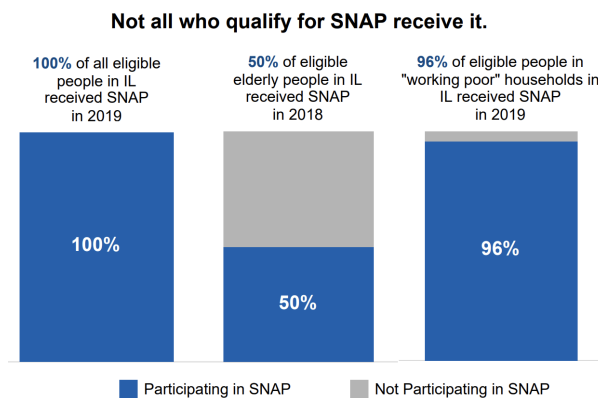
On a high level, Chicago's food insecurity rates have varied over the past decade. Rates were falling from around 2010 to 2020, but spiked back up as a result of COVID. This was improved by SNAP and other benefits put into place, but rates began to rise again as benefits were cut and prices rose.

During COVID, food insecurity rates were at an all-time high in Chicago. Hunger had always been a problem in Chicago, with an estimated 500,000 residents struggling, and COVID only exacerbated it, with food insecurity rates rising by 51% in 2020 (Food Depository Hunger Report). Prices have risen over time, too: in 2024, retail food prices had increased by 2.0% compared to the previous year, and the 10-year average increase per year for food prices in Chicago was 2.5% (Economic Research Service).

Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) benefits have played a key role in helping to mitigate the food insecurity struggle in Chicago. In 2022, 1,884,107 people across 1,028,197 households in Chicago received SNAP benefits, with the average monthly benefit coming out to \$157 per person. Eligibility for SNAP benefits is based on a number of factors; however, income can act as a key indicator, as 75% of those who received SNAP benefits had income at or below the poverty line. The following figure provides insight into the demographic breakdown of those who received SNAP benefits:



It is also important to note that not all who qualify for SNAP benefits actually receive them, as illustrated by the following figure:



The economics of SNAP benefits: An average of \$295.55 million was distributed each month in Chicago in 2022. Since SNAP benefits can only be spent on food, farmers, producers, distributors, and retailers all benefit. Approximately 9,277 food stores accept SNAP in Chicago. During periods of economic struggle, the multiplier effect is at play, where every \$1 in SNAP benefits can increase GDP by \$1.54 as benefits are spent immediately because people desperately need food, and hence sales increase (Food and Nutrition Service - entire paragraph).

Chicago is the largest city in Cook County. In Cook County, 1 in 4 children is at risk of hunger. The Greater Chicago Food Depository has been a crucial player in helping to combat food insecurity in Chicago. This fiscal year, 2025, they have provided 96 million meals across

2.3 million households through all of their food programs. Additionally, the depository has submitted 21,000 public benefit applications since 2020 on behalf of those in Cook County.